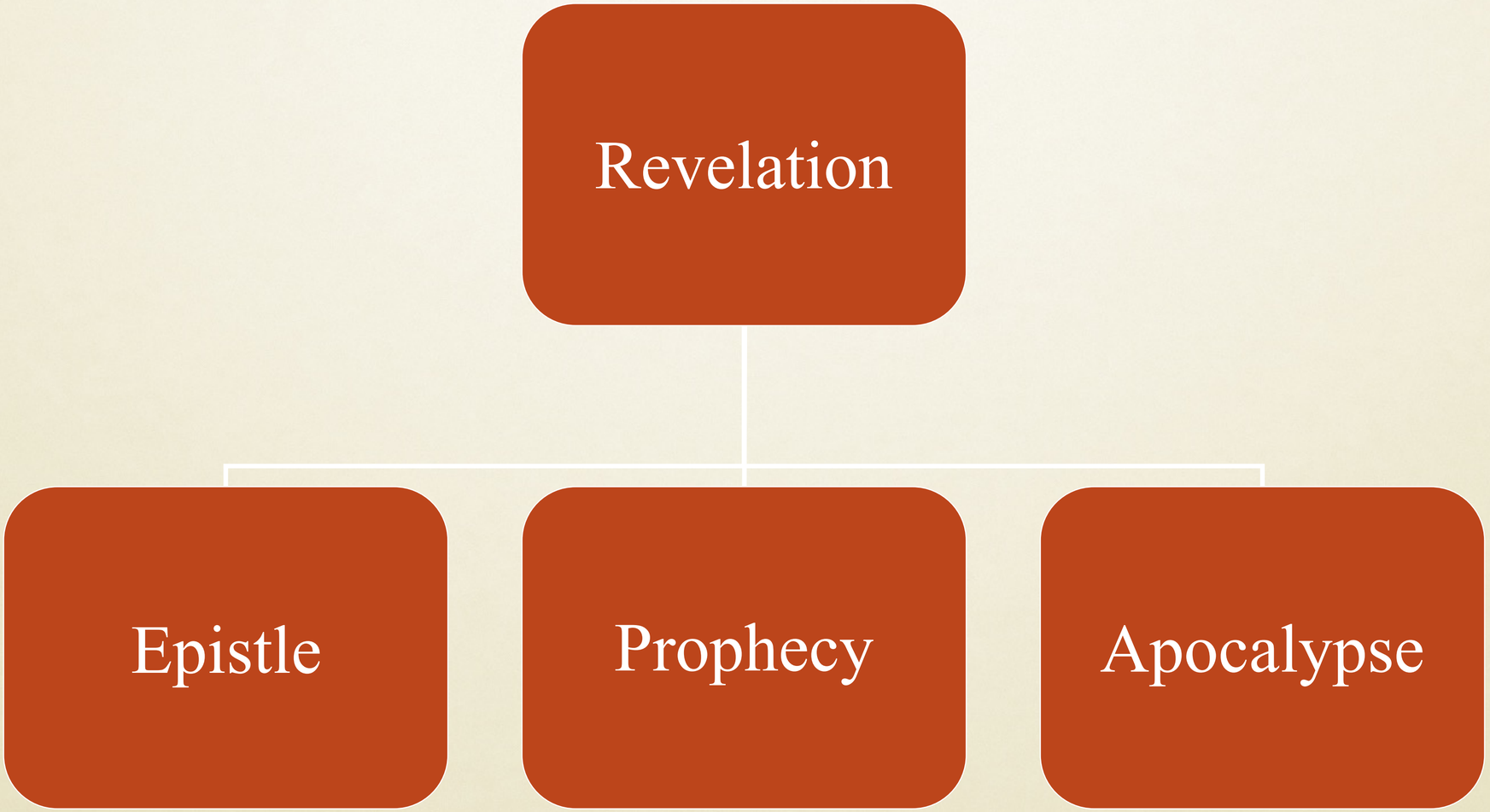
REVELATION

The Apocalypse of John

-Literature-

Literature of Revelation



Revelation an Epistle

- All normal C1st letter elements
- Begins as normal:
  - 1:1-3 – "John to the seven churches that are in Asia"
- Ends as normal:
  - 22:21 – "The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all the saints. Amen."

Revelation an Epistle

- Seven Churches in Asia are the original audience
- Book written for them
- Visions for them
- Interpretation has to be relevant for them
- All conclusions must be first from their perspective

Revelation a Prophecy

- Book declares itself to be a prophecy
  - 1:3, 22:7, 10, 18, 19
- O.T. Prophecy:
  - YHWH's words to his people
  - Warning to repent/hope for the faithful
- N.T. Prophecy:
  - Build up, encourage, console

Revelation a Prophecy

- Prophecy also predictive
  - Not “fortune telling”
  - “Prediction linked with preaching”
  - Present behaviour=future judgment
  - Present suffering=future relief
  - Present repentance=future will change

Revelation a Prophecy

- 2-3 – Preaching to the Churches
  - Also prediction of judgment & hope
- 4-22 – Prediction to the Churches
  - Also continuation of preaching
- Future visions have to be connected to 7 Church's present
- Prophecy is a message to who it was given to

Revelation an Apocalypse

- c200 BC – c100AD
- Term comes from Revelation itself
- Revelation of mysteries:
  - Heaven & Earth, Humanity & God, Angels & Demons, present & future
  - What is going on “behind the scenes”
- Peculiar style:
  - Symbols, imagery, beasts, spiritual forces…

Revelation an Apocalypse

- Roots in O.T. Prophecy:
  - Isaiah, Daniel, Ezekiel & Zechariah
  - Born from the written poetic messages
  - Apocalyptic images:
    - Isaiah – Egypt as a dragon, New Heaven/Earth
    - Daniel – Empires as beasts
    - Ezekiel – visions of YHWH/Temple
    - Zechariah – angels, strange visions, focus on Jerusalem

Revelation an Apocalypse

- Parts in N.T.:
  - Olivet Discourse (Mk. 13, Mt. 24 & Lk. 21)
  - Jude & 2 Peter quote other Apocalypses
- Apocrypha:
  - Greek version of Esther
  - 2 Esdras
- Non-canonical Apocalypses:
  - Book of Enoch, Assumption of Moses, Apocalypse of Baruch Book of Jubilees…

Revelation an Apocalypse

- Angels as guides/interpreters
- Backdrop of persecution
  - Reveals hope
- Vivid images
  - Dragons, beasts, whores etc.
  - Conflict between good & evil
  - More symbolic than literal
  - People/nations/cities represented by animals etc
  - Political events represented by cosmic events

Revelation an Apocalypse

- Numbers important
  - Convey concepts
  - E.g. – repetition of seven in Revelation

Revelation an Apocalypse

- Differences:
  - Revelation alone claims, and is recognised as inspired prophecy
  - Revelation written by who it claims to be written by
  - Revelation written before events predicted